

small arms and artillery. Others could be glimpsed, through the pall of smoke that soon descended, regrouping and charging again and again—several Federals counted up to 13 charges.

But in some places, the Confederates poured across the Union line, the battle surging back and forth around a barn, outbuildings, and brick farmhouse that belonged to the Carter family. Desperate hand-to-hand fighting spilled over fences into the gardens. Nightfall brought no letup in the frenzy; it only raged the more spectacularly along the main line of breastworks, where for hundreds of yards men standing three or four deep in the bloody ditches fired at each other over the parapet as quickly as they could be handed loaded rifles. One man described the muzzle flashes in the dark as “but one line of streaming fire.” The inconclusive battle sputtered to a halt by 9 p.m. At midnight a whispered order was passed down the Union line: “Fall in.” The Federals slipped away before dawn, heading north for Nashville, carrying at least 13 Confederate battle flags but leaving behind 2,500 casualties, including most of their seriously wounded.